

Lesotho



The landlocked Kingdom of Lesotho is entirely surrounded by – and economically dependent on – South Africa, which even sent in troops to restore calm after rioting in 1998.



GEOGRAPHY

A high mountainous plateau, cut by valleys and ravines. The Maluti Range runs through the center. The Drakensberg Range lies to the east.



CLIMATE

Temperate. Summers are hot with torrential rain storms. Snow is frequent in the mountains in winter.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The overwhelming majority of people are Sotho, though there are some South Asians, Europeans, and Chinese. A strong sense of national identity has tended to minimize ethnic tensions. Many men work as migrant laborers in South Africa, leaving women to run households.



INSIGHT: Lesotho has one of the highest literacy rates in Africa – but one of the highest rates of HIV/AIDS too



THE ECONOMY

Dependent on South Africa. Water and energy exported from new Highlands Water Scheme. Subsistence farming. Garment exports struggle to compete. HIV/AIDS is depleting workforce.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Kingdom of Lesotho

DATE OF FORMATION: 1966

CAPITAL: Maseru

POPULATION: 2.07 million

TOTAL AREA: 11,720 sq. miles
(30,355 sq. km)

DENSITY: 176 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: English*, Sesotho*, isiZulu

RELIGIONS: Christian 90%, traditional beliefs 10%

ETHNIC MIX: Sotho 97%, European and Asian 3%

GOVERNMENT: Parliamentary system

CURRENCY: Loti = 100 lisente